

April 29, 2026

To the Admissions Committee,

Thank you for the opportunity to recommend Sean Olson for admission to the Master of Science in Real Estate program at the NYU School of Professional Studies. I have come to know Sean closely during his time at Willamette University, where he has stood out as a leader and a dedicated student in my finance courses. Based on his academic performance and leadership, I would rank Sean in the top 1% of students I have taught at Willamette University.

Sean consistently came prepared for every lecture and was a highly active participant in our class discussions. What particularly impressed me was his intellectual curiosity and ability to engage deeply with complex material; he often asked thoughtful, insightful questions that showcased a level of critical thinking well beyond his peers. This commitment to learning is reflected in his 3.6 GPA and his success in quantitative coursework such as Finance, Accounting, and Excel Modeling. Furthermore, Sean possesses strong technical writing skills, evidenced by his ability to synthesize complex financial data into clear, professional reports—a skill set that confirms his readiness for graduate-level coursework.

Beyond his curiosity in the classroom, Sean has demonstrated exceptionally strong analytical skills. Through his role on the ASWU Finance Board, he performed cost-benefit analyses for a budget exceeding \$100,000 and mathematically adjusted funding bylaws to account for inflation. His ability to apply theory to real-world financial problems is also evident in his initiative to pursue the Real Estate Financial Modeling course through Wall Street Prep, signaling his readiness for the sophisticated investment and development analysis.

Sean's greatest strengths are his organizational discipline and his professional maturity. Sean is extremely organized, reliable, and hard-working. He has successfully balanced a rigorous academic load while excelling in significant leadership roles, such as serving as the President of the Japan Studies Student Leaders Club and as a Resident Advisor. His natural leadership

potential is further evidenced by his receipt of the "Senior Key," an honor awarded by Willamette University to the most outstanding seniors for their meritorious service to the student body. Furthermore, Sean possesses excellent communication skills. Whether he is mentoring international students through the American Studies Program or coordinating with local media outlets for large-scale events, he consistently demonstrates an ability to handle complex logistics and interpersonal dynamics with professional maturity.

As an area for growth, Sean sometimes takes on a high volume of responsibilities due to his desire to contribute to his community. While he manages these effectively, the rigorous environment at NYU will allow him to further refine his ability to prioritize high-level strategic tasks over tactical ones. Given his drive and "Senior Key" recognition for meritorious service, I have no doubt he possesses the overall potential for success in a rigorous academic environment like NYU SPS.

Sean is personable, intellectually curious, and possesses the drive necessary to succeed in a demanding graduate program. I have no doubt that he will produce excellent work at the graduate level in a global real estate hub like New York City and eventually make significant contributions to the real estate industry.

He has my highest recommendation for admission without reservation. Please feel free to contact me at 503-370-6883 or via email at ygu@willamette.edu if you require any further information.

Sincerely,

Yuqi (George) Gu
Associate Professor of Finance
Atkinson Graduate School of Management
Willamette University